

# HEAR, O ISRAEL

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*The One God, His Name, and the Mystery of His Fullness*

*“Hear, Israel: Yahweh is our God. Yahweh is one.”*

Deuteronomy 6:4 (WEB)

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## A Note on the Scriptures

Every verse is quoted from the **World English Bible (WEB)**, a public-domain translation free to read, copy, and share. The WEB renders God's personal name as "**Yahweh**," which is essential for a book about the name of God. Where the Hebrew and Greek matter, we will look underneath the English, but you do not need the original languages to follow.

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## A Note to Every Reader

Everything depends on this question. Not "does a god exist?" — but "who is the true God, and what is He like?" Get this wrong and everything downstream goes wrong; get it right and your whole life has found its center.

This book is about the God who introduced Himself to Israel with a name and a claim: *Yahweh is one*. We will take that confession with total seriousness — and then watch how the same Scriptures that guard God's oneness also reveal a fullness within it that no flat, solitary picture can contain.

**To the Christian:** this is the foundation under everything you believe.

**To the atheist or seeker:** start nowhere but the texts; follow what they actually say.

**To the Jewish reader:** the Shema is your treasure before it is anyone's, and we hold it with reverence. We will not caricature your faith. We believe these Scriptures reveal more than is often seen; you may disagree, and we will still call you friend.

**To the Muslim reader:** you confess that God is one and that idolatry is the gravest error. So do we. The dispute is not *whether* God is one but *who* the one God is — and that is worth examining together.

We compare beliefs; we never demean people. And we begin where Israel begins, every morning and every evening, with one sentence.

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# Chapter One — The Most Important Sentence

## The confession at the center of the world

There is a single sentence that a faithful Jew has recited twice a day for three thousand years, that mothers have whispered to children and martyrs have died with on their lips. It is called the *Shema*, after its first Hebrew word, "Hear":

*"Hear, Israel: Yahweh is our God. Yahweh is one. You shall love Yahweh your God with all your heart, with all your soul, and with all your might." — Deuteronomy 6:4-5 (WEB)*

Everything in the Bible rests on this rock. There is one God. He has a name — Yahweh. He alone is to be loved with the whole of one's being. Every other commandment is a footnote to this one.

And when Jesus of Nazareth was asked which commandment was the greatest, He did not offer a clever alternative. He quoted the Shema: "The first is, 'Hear, Israel, the Lord our God, the Lord is one'" (Mark 12:29-30). Whatever else this book claims, hear it now: **nothing in it asks you to abandon the Shema**. This is not a book that smuggles in extra gods. It is a book about who the one God of the Shema actually is.

## What "one" guards against

The oneness of God is not an abstract math fact. It is a fence around the human heart. Because God is one, He alone is worthy of worship; everything else — money, power, sex, self, the state, even religion itself — is a counterfeit when it takes His place. The first and second commandments draw the line: "You shall have no other gods before me. You shall not make for yourself an idol" (Exodus 20:3-4). Idolatry — giving to a created thing the trust and worship owed to the Creator — is the great sin precisely *because* God is one.

This is why the question "who is God?" is never merely intellectual. To know the true God is to know what your life is *for*. To mistake Him is to spend your life worshipping something that cannot save.

## A God who can be known

The most hopeful thing about the Shema is the word "our." "Yahweh is *our* God." The infinite Creator is not a distant abstraction to be guessed at; He has made Himself known, entered into covenant, and given His name. The rest of this book traces that self-revelation — and it starts with the most famous self-introduction in history, at a burning bush.

## Loved with the whole self

Notice that the Shema does not stop at "Yahweh is one." It immediately commands a response: "You shall love Yahweh your God with all your heart, with all your soul, and with all your might" (Deuteronomy 6:5). The confession of who God is leads straight into the claim God makes on us. The doctrine is not meant to be filed away; it is meant to capture the whole person — the affections ("heart"), the very life ("soul"), and the strength and resources ("might"). Nothing is left over for a rival.

This is why true monotheism is not a cold arithmetic of "one God rather than many," but a jealous love. To say "Yahweh is one" and then divide your heart among a dozen other devotions is to deny the Shema with your life while reciting it with your lips. The prophets called such a divided heart spiritual adultery. The God who is one asks not merely to be believed in but to be loved — wholly, the way He is wholly God.

And here is the mercy hidden in the command: we are made to love something with our whole selves. We will pour out our heart, soul, and might on *something* — a person, a cause, a hunger, an image of ourselves. The Shema does not crush that capacity; it aims it at the only One large enough to receive it without breaking. To love Yahweh with everything is not the loss of the self but its homecoming. Augustine said it best: God has made us for Himself, and our hearts are restless until they rest in Him.

## The God who speaks first

There is a quiet assumption buried in the Shema that is easy to miss, and it overturns most of what people assume about religion. Notice the first word: "*Hear*." Not "search," not "climb," not "achieve" — *hear*. Israel's faith does not begin with humanity reaching up to find God; it begins with God speaking, and humanity listening. The initiative is His.

This is the great difference between the God of the Bible and the gods of human imagination. The idols must be sought out, flattered, and figured out; the living God *introduces Himself*. He sought Abraham, not the reverse. He came down to a burning bush. He descended on Sinai. He spoke through the prophets. The whole Bible is the record of a God who will not stay hidden:

*"God, having in the past spoken to the fathers through the prophets at many times and in various ways, has at the end of these days spoken to us by his Son." — Hebrews 1:1-2 (WEB)*

This means knowing God is not finally a matter of human cleverness. The philosophers can reason their way to the *idea* of a first cause, and that is no small thing (Romans 1 says creation itself testifies to a Creator). But to know God as "*our* God" — by name, in covenant, as a person — we are dependent on His speech. He must tell us who He is, or we will only ever guess. And the staggering claim of the Shema is that He *has* told us. The conversation is already open. Our part is the first word of the creed itself: *hear*.

## Idols are never neutral

If God is one and worthy of the whole heart, then idolatry is never a harmless eccentricity; it is the great derangement of the soul. And the Bible says something startling about it: we become like whatever we worship.

*"Those who make them will be like them; yes, everyone who trusts in them." — Psalm 115:8 (WEB)*

The psalm has just described idols with mouths that cannot speak, eyes that cannot see, ears that cannot hear. Then comes the warning: their makers grow like them — blind, deaf, unfeeling. Worship is not a neutral activity we can take or leave; it is the most formative thing we do. We are shaped into the image of our god. Worship a god of money, and you become calculating and anxious. Worship a god of sex or self, and you become a slave to appetite. Worship a violent god, and you grow cruel. What we adore, we resemble.

Paul names the root of it: humanity "exchanged the truth of God for a lie, and worshiped and served the creature rather than the Creator" (Romans 1:25). Idolatry is an *exchange* — trading the living God for something smaller and more manageable. This is why the Shema's "one God" is not a constraint but a rescue: only the worship of the true God shapes us into what we were made to be — bearers of *His* image. The first commandment is not God hoarding our attention; it is God refusing to let us be deformed by lesser things. To know that God is one is to know there is only one Worship that will not shrink you.

And what we are told to hear is not a set of abstractions but the name and character of a Person who can be loved. Which raises the next question Moses asked at the bush, and we ask still: *what is His name?*

# Chapter Two — The Name

## "What is his name?"

Moses stands before a bush that burns but is not consumed, and the voice from the fire commissions him to free Israel. Moses asks the question everyone eventually asks: when they want to know who sent me, "What is his name?" And God answers with a sentence that has occupied theologians ever since:

*"God said to Moses, 'I AM WHO I AM,' and he said, 'You shall tell the children of Israel this: 'I AM has sent me to you.'"" — Exodus 3:14 (WEB)*

"I AM WHO I AM." In Hebrew, *ehyeh asher ehyeh* — a phrase built from the verb "to be." From it comes the sacred name, **YHWH** (Yahweh), which means something like "He Is," "the One who is," "the Self-Existent One." God's name is, astonishingly, a statement of pure being. Everything else that exists was made and could just as easily not exist. God simply *is* — uncreated, dependent on nothing, the source of all that is.

## A name that means He needs nothing

Pause on what this implies. A God whose name is "I AM" did not begin. He has no maker, no rival, no expiration. He does not need the universe; the universe needs Him every instant to continue existing. As Paul told the philosophers of Athens, this God is not "served by men's hands, as though he needed anything, seeing he himself gives to all life and breath, and all things" (Acts 17:25). The burning bush is the perfect emblem: a fire that needs no fuel, blazing on its own life.

## The name above every name

Israel held this name in such awe that they would not pronounce it, saying "the LORD" instead. It is the most sacred word in the Hebrew Scriptures. So keep this in mind for later, because it will matter enormously: when the New Testament says God gave Jesus "the name which is above every name" (Philippians 2:9), and applies to Jesus the words Yahweh spoke — that is not a small thing. It is a claim staked on this very name from the bush. But we are getting ahead of ourselves. First we must ask whether this transcendent "I AM" can have anything to do with us at all.

## The name that keeps its word

There is a second layer to the name that is easy to miss. The Hebrew *ehyeh* ("I am" / "I will be") is not only a statement of timeless existence; in its setting it is also a promise. God reveals this name at the very moment He is about to *act* — to come down, hear the cry of slaves, and rescue them. So the name carries the sense: "I am the One who is there, who will be there, who will be what I will be *for you*." The God whose being is self-existent is also the God who binds Himself to a people by covenant and keeps His word.

This is why, when God passes before Moses and proclaims the meaning of His name, it overflows not with abstract metaphysics but with character:

*"Yahweh! Yahweh, a merciful and gracious God, slow to anger, and abundant in loving kindness and truth, keeping loving kindness for thousands, forgiving iniquity and disobedience and sin." — Exodus 34:6-7 (WEB)*

That is the content of the Name. The "I AM" is merciful, gracious, patient, faithful, and forgiving. The same passage adds that He "will by no means clear the guilty" — His mercy is not the indulgence of evil. Hold those two together: a God abundant in steadfast love, who also takes sin with deadly seriousness. The whole drama of redemption is the question of how the God of Exodus 34 can be *both* at once — and the answer, the rest of the Bible will say, is a cross. The Name is not a riddle to be solved but a Person to be trusted.

## The name we stopped saying — and the name restored

Something poignant happened to the Name over the centuries. Out of reverence, Israel stopped pronouncing it aloud, substituting *Adonai* ("Lord") whenever they read it. Most English Bibles preserve this by printing "the LORD" in small capitals wherever the Hebrew has YHWH. The intention was holy — to guard the Name from misuse, in keeping with the command, "You shall not misuse the name of Yahweh your God" (Exodus 20:7). But over time the personal name of God receded almost into silence, and "God" can come to feel like a generic title rather than the name of Someone.

This matters for everything that follows, because the prophets promised that one day the Name would be *known* again — not merely spoken, but understood and trusted:

*"Therefore my people shall know my name. Therefore they shall know in that day that I am he who speaks. Behold, it is I." — Isaiah 52:6 (WEB)*

A day was coming when God's people would know His name in a new and personal way. And the New Testament makes a breathtaking move: it takes the Greek translation's word for the Name — *Kyrios*, "Lord," the very word that stood in for YHWH — and lavishes it on Jesus. "God highly exalted him, and gave to him the name which is above every name" (Philippians

2:9). The name that Israel would not even pronounce, God places on Jesus, "that at the name of Jesus every knee should bow... and that every tongue should confess that Jesus is Lord" (Philippians 2:10-11). This is not a coincidence of vocabulary. It is the deliberate claim that the long-guarded Name has now been spoken in full — as a Person, with a face. The Name we stopped saying has come to find us.

## The "I AM" who fills in the blank

There is a haunting echo of the burning-bush Name running through the Gospel of John. Seven times Jesus completes the divine "I am" with an image, painting a portrait of all that the "I AM" is *for* His people:

*"I am the bread of life" (John 6:35) · "I am the light of the world" (8:12) · "I am the door" (10:9) · "I am the good shepherd" (10:11) · "I am the resurrection and the life" (11:25) · "I am the way, the truth, and the life" (14:6) · "I am the true vine" (15:1).*

To a people who revered the Name from the bush, this drumbeat of "I am... I am... I am" was unmistakable. The eternal "I AM" — being itself, needing nothing — was now naming Himself in terms of what the hungry, the lost, the dying, and the wandering most need: bread, light, a door home, a shepherd, life out of death, the way to the Father. The God whose name means "He Is" was saying, in effect, "I am everything you cannot live without."

And then, dropping every image, Jesus spoke the Name absolutely: "Most certainly I tell you, before Abraham came into existence, I AM" (John 8:58) — and His hearers reached for stones, because they understood He had just spoken the unspeakable Name of Himself. The bush that burned without being consumed had, it turned out, been a preview. The self-existent "I AM" had a face all along, and one day He would stand in the temple and say so. (This single thread is the subject of our companion book, *I Am He*.)

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# Chapter Three — Is God a Man?

## The God who is not a creature

The Bible is emphatic that God is utterly unlike us. He is not a bigger, stronger version of a human being. "God is not a man, that he should lie, nor a son of man, that he should repent" (Numbers 23:19). He is spirit (John 4:24), eternal (Psalm 90:2), unchanging, present everywhere, knowing everything. He cannot be carved, contained, or controlled. This is His *transcendence* — He is above and beyond His creation.

This is the truth that idolatry forgets. To shrink God down to a statue, a force, or a projection of ourselves is to worship something less than God. The prophets pour scorn on the folly of a man who carves wood, burns half for warmth, and bows to the other half (Isaiah 44:14-17). The true God will not fit in a box.

## The God who comes near

And yet — here is the wonder that runs all through the Old Testament — this transcendent God is also astonishingly *near*. He walks in a garden. He shuts the door of the ark. He eats a meal with Abraham. He wrestles with Jacob, who then says, "I have seen God face to face, and my life is preserved" (Genesis 32:30). He comes down on Sinai in fire. He fills a tent with His glory and travels with a band of former slaves through a desert.

Most striking of all is a recurring figure the Old Testament calls **the Angel of Yahweh** — a messenger who is somehow both *distinct from* Yahweh and *identified as* Yahweh. He appears to Hagar, and she calls Him "a God who sees" (Genesis 16:13). He speaks from the burning bush as God. He receives worship that ordinary angels refuse. One of your own Scroll threads sat right here, at this strange figure who blesses, saves, and bears the very name of God while standing before us as a distinct person. The Old Testament is already hinting that God's nearness has a *face*.

## A nearness the heart longs for

When Jacob wakes from his dream of the ladder he cries, "Surely Yahweh is in this place, and I didn't know it" (Genesis 28:16). That is the ache of the whole Old Testament — the sense that the transcendent God is somehow present, and the longing to truly see Him. The Scriptures keep raising a hope they cannot yet satisfy: that the God who is "I AM" might one day be seen and known, face to face, without anyone being destroyed. That hope is not idle. It is being prepared. But first we must notice something hidden inside the oneness itself.

## "I will dwell among them"

The deepest desire of the God of the Bible is not to stay safely transcendent but to *dwell with* His people. The whole design of the tabernacle flows from one stated purpose:

*"Let them make me a sanctuary, that I may dwell among them." — Exodus 25:8*  
(WEB)

The infinite Creator, who cannot be contained by the highest heaven (1 Kings 8:27), chooses to pitch a tent in the middle of a camp of former slaves so He can be near them. This is the astonishing pattern of the whole story: not a God who keeps His distance, but a God who keeps coming closer.

Yet there is a barrier, and the Old Testament is honest about it. When Moses asks to see God's glory, the answer is sobering: "You cannot see my face, for man may not see me and live" (Exodus 33:20). The problem is not that God is unwilling to be near, but that we are sinful and He is holy, and holiness is not safe for the unholy. So God draws near *behind a veil*, through sacrifice, in glimpses — His back, not His face; a cloud, not the full blaze. The transcendent God genuinely comes near, but the nearness is always mediated, always pointing beyond itself to a day when the veil might finally be taken away and we could see His face and live. That ache — *to dwell with God and see Him without dying* — is the hunger the rest of the Bible sets out to satisfy. Hold it; it will be answered in a manger and an empty tomb.

## Both at once: high and near

The deepest answer to "Is God a man?" is not a flat "no." It is "No — and yet." For the same Scriptures that put God beyond our reach also insist He stoops to the lowest. Isaiah holds both in a single breath, and it is worth reading slowly:

*"For the high and lofty One who inhabits eternity, whose name is Holy, says: 'I dwell in the high and holy place, with him also who is of a contrite and humble spirit, to revive the spirit of the humble, and to revive the heart of the contrite ones.'" — Isaiah 57:15 (WEB)*

Read that again. The One who "inhabits eternity," whose name is "Holy," dwells in "the high and holy place" — *and* with the crushed and lowly. Not instead of His transcendence, but alongside it. This is the signature of the true God: He is most high and most near at once, and His nearness runs not to the proud and self-sufficient but to the broken. "Yahweh is near to those who have a broken heart, and saves those who have a crushed spirit" (Psalm 34:18).

False gods are either far (cold abstractions, deist clockmakers) or near in a debased way (idols you can manage and manipulate). The God of the Bible refuses both errors. He is too holy to be controlled and too loving to stay away. And this is precisely the tension the incarnation resolves: in Jesus, "the high and lofty One who inhabits eternity" came to dwell with the contrite — not by ceasing to be God, but by taking up our nature so that the unapproachable became approachable, and the God no one could see and live became the God a fisherman could lean against at supper. "Is God a man?" The Bible's astonishing answer is that the eternal God *became* one, without ever stopping being God — so that we might live.

## What He keeps hidden, and what He shows

A God this great will always exceed us. There will always be more of Him than we can grasp — and Scripture is honest that some things God simply has not told us. Moses set the boundary plainly:

*"The secret things belong to Yahweh our God, but the things that are revealed belong to us and to our children forever." — Deuteronomy 29:29 (WEB)*

This is a liberating sentence. It means we are not required to solve every mystery about God before we can trust Him. The "secret things" — the unsearchable depths of His being, the hidden reasons behind His providence — belong to Him. The "revealed things" — His name, His character, His commands, His salvation — belong to *us*, and are enough to live and die on. Faith is not pretending to know what God has not revealed; it is trusting what He *has* revealed about His character when His ways are past finding out.

*"For as the heavens are higher than the earth, so are my ways higher than your ways, and my thoughts than your thoughts," says Yahweh." — Isaiah 55:8-9 (WEB)*

That God's thoughts tower over ours is not a reason for despair but for humility and rest. A god small enough to be fully comprehended would be too small to be God. The wonder is that this incomprehensible God has stooped to make Himself *known* — not exhaustively, but truly and savingly. We will spend eternity coming to know Him better and never reach the bottom. That is not frustration; it is the promise of unending discovery, an ocean we will explore forever and never drain.

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# Chapter Four — The Fullness Within the One

## A plural hint on the first page

Return to the very beginning. On the sixth day, God says something that has puzzled readers for millennia:

*"God said, 'Let us make man in our image, after our likeness.'" — Genesis 1:26*  
(WEB)

*Us. Our.* The one God speaks of Himself in the plural. Some explain this as God addressing angels — but angels are not co-creators, and humanity is made in *God's* image, not the angels'. Others call it a royal "we." But the hint does not stand alone. Already in Genesis 1:2 "the Spirit of God was hovering over the surface of the waters" — God, and the Spirit of God, both present at creation. And throughout the Old Testament, the "Word" of Yahweh and the "Wisdom" of God act as if they are more than poetic figures (Proverbs 8; Psalm 33:6).

We must be careful here, and honest. None of this *by itself* proves the doctrine of the Trinity, and we will not pretend it does. What it shows is that the oneness of the God of Israel was never the flat, solitary oneness of a single isolated person. There is a fullness, a complexity, a "within-ness" to God that the Hebrew Scriptures themselves keep gesturing toward.

## "Two powers in heaven"

This is not a Christian imposition on the text. Ancient Jewish interpreters wrestled with the same data. The Scriptures show Yahweh on earth talking with Yahweh in heaven (Genesis 19:24); they show a figure called the Word, the Angel, the Wisdom of God acting *as* God yet *distinct* from God. So strong were these threads that some rabbis spoke of "two powers in heaven" — and the later authorities worked hard to rule the idea out, precisely because some Jews were drawing from their own Scriptures the very conclusion the New Testament would draw. The point is simple and important: the question of plurality-within-the-one arises *from the Hebrew Bible itself*, not from outside it.

## A throne, and Someone seated on it

Then the prophet Daniel sees the curtain pulled back. In heaven, "the Ancient of Days" takes His throne — and then "one like a son of man came with the clouds of the sky," approached

the Ancient of Days, and was given "dominion, and glory, and a kingdom, that all the peoples, nations, and languages should serve him" (Daniel 7:13-14). Here are two distinct figures in the one heavenly throne-room, and to the human-yet-heavenly one is given the worship and everlasting kingdom that, by the Shema, belong to God alone. The fullness within the One is coming into focus. The Old Testament has been preparing us, slowly, to meet Him.

## The Word and the Wisdom of God

Two more threads deserve a closer look, because the New Testament will grab both of them. The first is the **Word** of God. Genesis says God *spoke* creation into being — "God said, 'Let there be light,' and there was light" — and the Psalms turn that into a near-personification: "By Yahweh's word the heavens were made, all their army by the breath of his mouth" (Psalm 33:6). God's Word is not mere sound; it is the living agent by which He makes and rules the world. Ancient Jewish translators were so struck by this that, when they rendered the Scriptures into Aramaic, they often spoke of the *Memra* (the "Word") of the Lord as the one who acted, created, and saved — a way of speaking about God's nearness without diminishing His transcendence.

The second thread is **Wisdom**. In Proverbs, Wisdom speaks as a person who was with God before the world began:

*"When he established the heavens, I was there... then I was the craftsman by his side. I was his delight day by day, always rejoicing before him." — Proverbs 8:27, 30 (WEB)*

Read it slowly: Wisdom is "by his side," God's delight, a craftsman at creation — distinct enough to be *beside* God, yet so bound to God as to be His own Wisdom. Christians do not claim Proverbs 8 is a bare proof-text for the Son; it is poetry about God's wisdom. But notice the *shape* of the language — a someone, with God, through whom God creates and delights — and then hear how John opens his Gospel: "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God... All things were made through him" (John 1:1-3). The Word who spoke creation, the Wisdom who was the craftsman beside God — these were never merely figures of speech. They were the shadow of a Person, falling backward across the Hebrew Scriptures from a light that had not yet risen.

## The Angel who is Yahweh

Of all the Old Testament's hints of fullness within the One, the strangest and most insistent is a figure called *the Angel of Yahweh* — and He repays a closer look, because He is plainly not an ordinary angel. Ordinary angels refuse worship and speak *for* God ("thus says the Lord").

This figure receives worship and speaks as God, in the first person, while still being somehow distinct from the God who sends Him.

Watch it happen. To Hagar, alone in the desert, "the angel of Yahweh" speaks — and then she names the One who spoke to her *as God Himself*:

*"She called the name of Yahweh who spoke to her, 'You are a God who sees,' for she said, 'Have I even stayed alive after seeing him?'" — Genesis 16:13 (WEB)*

At the burning bush, "the angel of Yahweh appeared to him in a flame of fire" (Exodus 3:2) — and then it is *Yahweh* and *God* who speaks from it, saying "I am the God of your father" (Exodus 3:6), and Moses "was afraid to look at God." The Angel and Yahweh are named interchangeably. When Jacob blesses Joseph's sons, he prays to "the God before whom my fathers Abraham and Isaac walked" and "the angel who has redeemed me from all evil" as one and the same (Genesis 48:15-16). When Gideon and later Manoah realize they have seen "the angel of Yahweh" face to face, they cry out in terror that they will die — the dread reserved for seeing *God* (Judges 6:22-23; 13:21-22).

What are we to make of a "messenger" who is both sent by Yahweh and *is* Yahweh, who bears the divine name, receives worship, and forgives or redeems? Ancient readers felt the pressure of it. The pattern does not prove the doctrine of the Trinity by itself — we keep saying so — but it lays the track. It teaches Israel, slowly, that the one God can be present as a distinct *someone* who is fully Himself, can be seen and spoken with, without ceasing to be the unseeable God on the throne. By the time the Word becomes flesh, the category is not foreign. The God who walked as the Angel of Yahweh through the patriarchs' stories was preparing His people for the day He would walk among them as a man.

## The breath, the word, and the hand of God

The Hebrew Scriptures have a whole vocabulary for the *one* God acting in the world through what seem almost like agents of Himself — His Word, His Spirit (in Hebrew *ruach*, "breath"), His Wisdom, His Hand, His Arm, His Name, His Glory. These are not separate gods, nor mere metaphors to be dismissed; they are the ways the transcendent God reaches into His creation while remaining transcendent. Watch how His Word and His Breath act together at creation:

*"By Yahweh's word the heavens were made, all their army by the breath of his mouth." — Psalm 33:6 (WEB)*

The Word that commands and the Breath that animates — God's own speech and God's own Spirit — together make the heavens. And when God redeems, it is again His "arm" and His "hand": "Yahweh's hand is not shortened, that it can't save" (Isaiah 59:1). These are not God

outsourcing His work to subordinates; they are God Himself present and active, near and powerful, without the infinite being ever localized or contained.

Why does this matter for the doctrine of the Trinity? Because it shows, again, that Israel's monotheism was never a flat, featureless oneness. The one God has always been pictured as *richly* one — speaking by His Word, acting by His Breath, saving by His Arm. When the New Testament reveals that the Word is a divine Person who became flesh, and the Spirit is a divine Person poured out on the church, it is not bolting strangers onto God. It is naming, at last, the Word and the Breath that were there "in the beginning," hovering over the waters, making the heavens, reaching down to save.

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# Chapter Five — Father, Son, and Holy Spirit

## The fullness with a face

What the Old Testament hinted, the New Testament unveils — not by adding gods, but by revealing that the one God has eternally existed as Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. The Word who was with God and was God "became flesh and lived among us" (John 1:1, 14). The ache of Jacob — "surely God is in this place" — is answered: in Jesus, the "I AM" of the burning bush has a face. "He who has seen me has seen the Father" (John 14:9).

Watch how the persons appear together, distinct yet one. At Jesus' baptism the Son stands in the water, the Spirit descends like a dove, and the Father's voice speaks from heaven: "This is my beloved Son" (Matthew 3:16-17) — three, at once, in one scene. Jesus sends His followers to baptize "in *the name*" — singular — "of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit" (Matthew 28:19): one name, three persons. Paul blesses the church with "the grace of the Lord Jesus Christ, God's love, and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit" (2 Corinthians 13:14).

## Not three gods, not one mask

The church's confession — what later came to be called the Trinity — holds two truths together without dropping either. *God is one* (the Shema stands). And *the one God is Father, Son, and Holy Spirit*, three distinct persons sharing one undivided being.

This is not three gods. That would be tritheism, and it would break the Shema. Nor is it one person wearing three masks — Father today, Son tomorrow — which the early church rejected as modalism, because the Son prays to the Father (John 17), the Father speaks to the Son, and they love one another "before the foundation of the world" (John 17:24). A mask cannot love itself across eternity. The relationship is real and eternal.

## Why the word "Trinity" is not in the Bible — and the reality is

Some object that the word "Trinity" never appears in Scripture. True — and neither does "monotheism," yet the Bible is thoroughly monotheistic. "Trinity" is the church's faithful shorthand for what the Bible everywhere teaches: one God (Deuteronomy 6:4), the Father is God, the Son is God (John 1:1; John 20:28), the Spirit is God (Acts 5:3-4), and they are distinct. The word summarizes the data; it does not invent it. The God who said "let us" in the garden, who appeared as the Angel who is Yahweh, who showed Daniel two thrones, has

stepped fully into the light. He is one — and He is fullness of life and love within Himself.

## One God, undivided in work

It helps to see *how* the persons act, because the Bible never shows them working against one another or even merely side by side, like a committee. They act *together*, inseparably, in everything God does. Creation is from the Father, through the Son ("all things were made through him," John 1:3), by the Spirit who hovered over the waters. Salvation is planned by the Father, accomplished by the Son, and applied by the Spirit. Paul can rework the Shema itself around two of the persons without breaking it: "to us there is one God, the Father... and one Lord, Jesus Christ" (1 Corinthians 8:6) — taking the two words of the Shema, "God" and "Lord (Yahweh)," and naming the Father and the Son, while still insisting there is *one*.

This is why the doctrine is not three gods cooperating but one God acting in the fullness of His own life. And it answers the deepest objection of all — *why three?* Because God is love (1 John 4:8), and love requires an object. A solitary single person could not have *been* love before creation; he could only have become loving once he had someone to love. But the triune God did not need to create in order to love, for the Father has eternally loved the Son in the Spirit. "You loved me before the foundation of the world," Jesus prays (John 17:24). The fullness within the One means that love is not something God *does*; it is something God eternally *is*. That is not an abstract puzzle. It is the best news about the universe: at the bottom of all reality is not cold force or lonely power, but self-giving love, older than time.

## A family before He ever made one

Press a little further into that love, because it changes how we understand everything God does. Jesus prays, on the night before He dies, words that lift the curtain on eternity past:

*"Father, I desire that they also whom you have given me be with me where I am, that they may see my glory, which you have given me, for you loved me before the foundation of the world." — John 17:24 (WEB)*

"You loved me *before the foundation of the world*." Before there was a universe, before there was anything to create or rule or redeem, the Father was loving the Son in the joy of the Spirit. God was never lonely, never incomplete, never in need of company. He was already a fellowship of self-giving love — a "family," if you will, before He ever made one.

This has enormous consequences. It means God did not create us because He was lacking something; He created out of the overflow of a love that was already full. It means that when Genesis says we are made in God's image — "*Let us make man in our image*" — part of what

is stamped on us is a capacity for relationship and love, because we image a God who is, in His very being, relationship and love. And it means the goal of salvation is not merely to be forgiven but to be *brought in* — to "be with me where I am," to be drawn into the very love the Father and Son have shared from before the world began. The triune God does not save us into a transaction. He saves us into a family that has existed, in perfect joy, forever.

## The Spirit is God, not God's energy

It is worth pausing on the third person, because the Holy Spirit is the one most often misunderstood — reduced to a force, an influence, an "it." Scripture will not allow it. The Spirit is not God's *energy*; the Spirit is God, a *someone* who can be spoken to, grieved, and lied to. In the early church, when a man named Ananias lied about a gift, Peter's words are decisive:

*"Why has Satan filled your heart to lie to the Holy Spirit...? You haven't lied to men, but to God." — Acts 5:3-4 (WEB)*

Read the two sentences together: to lie to the Holy Spirit *is* to lie to God. The equation could not be plainer. And the Spirit acts as only a person can: He "searches all things, yes, the deep things of God" (1 Corinthians 2:10), He speaks ("the Holy Spirit said, 'Set apart for me Barnabas and Saul,'" Acts 13:2), He can be grieved ("don't grieve the Holy Spirit of God," Ephesians 4:30), He intercedes for us "with groanings which can't be uttered" (Romans 8:26). You do not grieve a force or lie to an influence. You grieve a person you have wronged.

This matters intensely for the Christian life, because the Spirit is how the transcendent God comes to dwell *inside* His people — the deepest fulfillment of "I will dwell among them." "Don't you know that you are a temple of God, and that God's Spirit lives in you?" (1 Corinthians 3:16). The God who once filled a tabernacle with cloud and a temple with glory now fills *people* with Himself. The Spirit is not a lesser divine helper but God in His nearest nearness — the same one Yahweh, drawing so close as to take up residence in the human heart.

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# Chapter Six — Besides Me There Is No Savior

## The God who shares His glory with no one

If God is one, then He alone can save, and He will not hand His glory to a rival. Yahweh says it through Isaiah with total finality:

*"I, even I, am Yahweh; and besides me there is no savior." — Isaiah 43:11 (WEB)*

*"Look to me, and be saved, all the ends of the earth; for I am God, and there is no other." — Isaiah 45:22 (WEB)*

This is the most exclusive claim imaginable. Salvation comes from Yahweh alone. Worship belongs to Yahweh alone. "To me every knee will bow, every tongue will swear" (Isaiah 45:23). To give that worship to any creature would be the very idolatry the Shema forbids.

## Why this is the hinge of everything

Hold those verses next to what the New Testament says about Jesus, and you face a decision with no middle ground. The earliest Christians — Jews who would have died before bowing to an idol — took Isaiah's no-knee-bows-but-to-God text and applied it directly to Jesus: "at the name of Jesus every knee should bow... and every tongue should confess that Jesus is Lord, to the glory of God the Father" (Philippians 2:10-11). They took the saving God "besides whom there is no savior" and confessed, "There is salvation in no one else" — in Jesus (Acts 4:12).

Either this is blasphemy — giving God's glory to a creature — or it is the unveiling of who the one God always was. There is no third option where Jesus is merely a great prophet who happens to receive the worship reserved for Yahweh. The Shema forces the question to a point: *is the Lord Jesus the one Lord God, or not?* This ministry's companion book, *I Am He*, follows that single thread in detail. Here it is enough to see that the exclusive, saving, glory-jealous God of Isaiah is the God the New Testament says we meet in Christ.

## One God for all the nations

And notice the reach of it — "all the ends of the earth." The one God is not a tribal deity for one people. He is the Creator of every nation, and His salvation is offered to all. As Paul told the Athenians, "He made from one blood every nation of men to dwell on all the surface of the

earth... that they should seek the Lord, if perhaps they might reach out for him and find him, though he is not far from each one of us" (Acts 17:26-27). The Shema's "our God" was always meant to open outward until the whole earth is filled with the knowledge of His glory.

## The jealousy that is love

There is one more word that troubles modern readers: God says He is *jealous*. "You shall not bow yourself down to them, nor serve them, for I, Yahweh your God, am a jealous God" (Exodus 20:5). Jealousy sounds like a flaw — petty, insecure, controlling. But there is a jealousy that is not a vice; it is the proper response of love to betrayal. A husband who felt *nothing* at his wife's unfaithfulness would not be more loving but less. He would be indifferent. God's jealousy is the measure of how real His love is: He will not share the heart that belongs to Him with idols that can only destroy it, any more than a faithful spouse will calmly hand the beloved over to what will ruin them.

This reframes the whole question of God's exclusivity. "Besides me there is no savior" and "I am a jealous God" are not the tyrant's demands; they are the lover's. The prophets press the image relentlessly: idolatry is *adultery*, and the God who pursues His unfaithful people is the wounded but unrelenting husband who will not let them go (see the whole book of Hosea). So when God forbids other gods, He is not protecting His ego; He is protecting *us* — for to worship what cannot save is to give our hearts to what cannot keep them. The first commandment is the first mercy. The God who will not share His glory is the God who will not share *you* with the things that would devour you.

## One door, wide open

People sometimes recoil at the exclusivity: *only one God, only one Savior, only one way*? It can sound narrow. But consider what the alternative would actually mean. If there were many saviors, many of them would be false, and you could not know which lifeline would hold your weight. The Bible's claim is not that God has cruelly limited the exits, but that He has provided a sure one — and flung it wide open to everyone.

For the same prophet who says "besides me there is no savior" issues the most universal invitation in the Old Testament:

*"Look to me, and be saved, all the ends of the earth; for I am God, and there is no other." — Isaiah 45:22 (WEB)*

The exclusivity and the welcome are one sentence. *There is no other* — and therefore *all the ends of the earth* may come to this One and be saved. It is one door, but it is wide, and it is

open, and no one who comes to it is turned away. The New Testament keeps both halves: "There is salvation in no one else" (Acts 4:12), *and* "whoever calls on the name of the Lord will be saved" (Romans 10:13) — and just before that, "the same Lord is Lord of all, and is rich to all who call on him" (Romans 10:12). No "Jew or Greek," no insider or outsider; the one Savior is rich to *all* who call.

So the question raised by God's oneness is not "why so narrow?" but "will you come to the One who is there?" A single bridge over a chasm is not an insult; it is a rescue, if it is the bridge that holds. The Bible's witness is that this One holds — and that He bids the whole earth cross over.

## The day the idols fall

The Bible is not naïve about the rival gods. It knows the whole earth is crowded with them — and it predicts their end. The prophets pour holy mockery on the idols precisely because they are *nothing*: a man plants a tree, cuts it down, burns half to cook his dinner, and "of the rest he makes a god, even his engraved image. He bows down to it and worships, and prays to it, and says, 'Deliver me; for you are my god!'" (Isaiah 44:17). The absurdity is the point. What cannot save itself from the fire cannot save you.

And so the one God promises a day when every counterfeit collapses and He alone is seen for who He is:

*"The lofty looks of man will be brought low, the haughtiness of men will be bowed down, and Yahweh alone will be exalted in that day. The idols will utterly pass away." — Isaiah 2:17-18 (WEB)*

History is going somewhere, and its destination is the public vindication of the one God. The prophet Zechariah states the end of the whole story in a single line that gathers up the Shema and flings it across the entire globe:

*"Yahweh will be King over all the earth. In that day Yahweh will be one, and his name one." — Zechariah 14:9 (WEB)*

That is where the confession "Yahweh is one" is heading — not to a private creed for one people, but to the day when the oneness of God is acknowledged by *all the earth*, every idol fallen, every knee bowed. This is the very future this ministry is named for: "the earth will be filled with the knowledge of the glory of Yahweh, as the waters cover the sea" (Habakkuk 2:14). The question the Shema puts to you is simply whether you will bow now, gladly, to the One before whom the whole earth will one day bow — and find, in bowing, not defeat but home.



# Chapter Seven — Knowing God

## From information to worship

You can know a great deal *about* God and never know *Him* — just as you can memorize a person's biography and never meet them. The point of all the doctrine in this book is not to win arguments. It is to bring you to the place where information becomes worship, where "I AM" becomes "*my* God."

The Bible promises this is possible — indeed it is the entire goal. Jeremiah foretold a day when God's people "shall all know me, from the least of them to the greatest" (Jeremiah 31:34). Jesus said eternal life *is* this knowing: "This is eternal life, that they should know you, the only true God, and him whom you sent, Jesus Christ" (John 17:3). To know God is not the reward at the end of the Christian life; it is the Christian life.

## How the unknowable God can be known

So how does a finite, sinful person come to know the infinite, holy God? Not by climbing up to Him through cleverness or merit — we cannot. The wonder of the gospel is that He came down. The "I AM" who could not be looked upon at Sinai became approachable in Jesus, "the image of the invisible God" (Colossians 1:15). "No one has seen God at any time. The one and only Son... has declared him" (John 1:18). If you want to know what God is like — His heart, His holiness, His mercy toward sinners — look at Jesus, and you are looking at God making Himself known.

And the knowing is not merely intellectual; it is by the Spirit. The same God who is Father and Son is the Spirit who "searches all things, yes, the deep things of God" (1 Corinthians 2:10) and who opens the eyes of the heart. To know God truly, you must be brought to Him by God Himself.

## The first step into the knowing

Which means the question this whole book has been circling lands, finally, on you. You have heard who God is: the one Yahweh, the "I AM," transcendent yet near, full of life and love within Himself, Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, the only Savior, who made every nation and is "not far from each one of us." The Shema's command was never merely "believe that God is one." It was "*love* Yahweh your God with all your heart." Knowledge is meant to become love.

You can begin to know Him today. Turn from whatever has held the place that belongs to God alone — that is repentance. Trust the Son in whom the invisible God has drawn near — that is faith. Call on Him, for "everyone who will call on the name of the Lord will be saved" (Romans 10:13). You might pray, simply: *God, I want to know you — the true God, not an idol of my own making. I have given your place to other things, and I turn from them. I trust Jesus, in whom you came near. Make yourself known to me, and be my God.*

The God whose name is "I AM" has been saying, in effect, from the burning bush to the empty tomb: *I am here. I am near. Hear, and live.*

## The Spirit who teaches us to say "Father"

Do not miss how intimate the knowing finally becomes. The God of the burning bush, before whom Moses hid his face, the God whose glory could not be looked upon and lived — this same God, by His Spirit, teaches the people He saves to call Him by the tenderest of names:

*"You received the Spirit of adoption, by whom we cry, 'Abba! Father!' The Spirit himself testifies with our spirit that we are children of God." — Romans 8:15-16*  
(WEB)

*Abba* is the word of a child to a trusted father — closer to "Papa" than to a formal title. That the transcendent "I AM" should be addressed so by former rebels is the whole distance of the Bible traveled in a single word: from the unapproachable fire of Sinai to a child climbing into a Father's lap. And it is the Spirit — God Himself within us — who makes us able to say it. We do not work our way up to this intimacy; it is given. The doctrine of God, rightly received, does not end in a lecture hall. It ends in a family. The point of knowing who God is, is to come home to Him.

## Where all true theology ends

There is a test for whether you have learned the doctrine of God rightly, and it is not whether you can win a debate. It is whether your knowing turns to *worship*. The apostle Paul, having written the most theologically dense chapters in all his letters — page after page on the nature and ways of God — cannot hold it in. The argument breaks open into song:

*"Oh the depth of the riches both of the wisdom and the knowledge of God! How unsearchable are his judgments, and his ways past tracing out!... For from him and through him and to him are all things. To him be the glory forever! Amen." — Romans 11:33, 36* (WEB)

That is where all true theology ends — not in a conclusion but in a doxology; not "therefore I have figured God out," but "to him be the glory forever." The more truly you come to know this God — one, eternal, holy, near, triune, the only Savior — the smaller you become and the larger He grows, until the only fitting response is to fall down. The theologians who knew God best were not the ones with the cleverest systems but the ones who ended on their faces.

So if this book has done its work, it has not merely filled your mind; it has bent your knee. The knowledge of God is given not to make us experts but to make us worshippers — and one day, to make us see. "Beloved, now we are children of God, and it is not yet revealed what we will be. But we know that when he is revealed, we will be like him; for we will see him just as he is" (1 John 3:2). The ache of Moses, who could see only God's back, and of Jacob, who marveled that God was in that place — that ache will finally be answered. We will see His face, and live.

*"You will seek me, and find me, when you search for me with all your heart." —  
Jeremiah 29:13 (WEB)*

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# Honest Questions

No doctrine raises more honest questions than the doctrine of God. Here are the ones most often asked — from believers and skeptics alike — answered briefly and without evasion.

## "Isn't the Trinity a contradiction — three is not one?"

Only if we say God is three *and* one in the *same way* — three persons and one person, or three gods and one god. That would be a contradiction, and the church has never taught it. We say God is one in one respect (one Being, one "What") and three in another (three persons, three "Whos"). One *what*, three *whos*. There is no more contradiction in that than in saying a single human being has one nature and a single will, or that one triangle has three sides — the categories are different. Mystery is not the same as contradiction. The doctrine is *above* our full comprehension, as the infinite God must be; it is not *against* reason.

## "Was the Trinity invented at the Council of Nicaea (325)?"

No. Nicaea *defended* what the church had believed and worshipped from the start, against a new teaching (Arianism) that the Son was a created being. The raw materials were all there centuries earlier: the Word who "was God" (John 1:1, c. AD 90), the worship of Jesus in the earliest letters (Philippians 2:9-11, a hymn Paul *quotes*, meaning it was older still), baptism in the threefold name (Matthew 28:19), and the apostolic blessing of Father, Son, and Spirit (2 Corinthians 13:14). Councils put fences around old beliefs; they do not manufacture them. The word "Trinity" is later shorthand; the reality is apostolic.

## "If Jesus is God, why did He pray, and why did He say 'the Father is greater than I' (John 14:28)?"

Because the Son became truly human. Christians do not believe Jesus stopped being God; we believe the eternal Son took on a full human nature — "the Word became flesh" (John 1:14). As man, He prayed, grew tired, wept, and depended on the Father. "The Father is greater than I" speaks of His role and His state in the incarnation (the sent One, in the lowliness of human flesh), not of a lesser nature — for in the very same Gospel He says, "I and the Father are one" (John 10:30), and "he who has seen me has seen the Father" (John 14:9). A son can be fully equal to his father in nature while submitting to him in role. So it is with the eternal Son.

## **"Doesn't Jesus' not knowing the day or hour (Mark 13:32) prove He isn't God?"**

It proves He is truly *human*. In taking our nature, the Son lived within real human limits — He "increased in wisdom" as a child (Luke 2:52), grew hungry, and, in His humanity, did not draw on all divine knowledge at every moment. This is the wonder of the incarnation, not its undoing: the infinite One stooped to live a genuinely human life. The same Jesus also knew people's hidden thoughts (Mark 2:8), knew the future in detail, and accepted worship. Scripture holds His full deity and full humanity together; cherry-picking the human moments no more disproves His deity than the divine moments disprove His humanity.

## **"What about Psalm 82, where God calls others 'gods'?"**

Psalm 82 pictures God standing in judgment over the "gods" — most likely Israel's *judges* or rulers (or, on another reading, spiritual powers) who were entrusted with authority and abused it: "I said, 'You are gods'... Nevertheless you shall die like men" (Psalm 82:6-7). The point is the *opposite* of polytheism: these so-called "gods" are mortal and will be judged by the one true God. When Jesus cites this psalm (John 10:34-36), He is making a lesser-to-greater argument — if Scripture could call mere mortal judges "gods" in that delegated sense, the charge of blasphemy against the One the Father truly sanctified and sent is unfounded. Psalm 82 does not dilute monotheism; it dramatizes it.

## **"Isn't it arrogant to say there is only one true God?"**

Every worldview makes a truth claim, including the claim that "all paths are equally valid" (which is itself an exclusive claim that excludes those who disagree). The question is not whether someone is making a claim, but whether the claim is *true*. If God has actually revealed Himself — with a name, in history, supremely in a Person who rose from the dead — then to receive that revelation is not arrogance but humility before the evidence. And the God who says "besides me there is no savior" also says, in the same breath, "Look to me, and be saved, all the ends of the earth" (Isaiah 45:22). The exclusivity and the open invitation are the same sentence.

## **"Aren't all the gods of the religions really the same God?"**

It is a kind and popular thought, but it cannot survive a close look — and respecting each faith means taking its actual claims seriously rather than blurring them. The religions do not merely

describe the same God with different names; they make *contradictory* claims about His very nature. Is God one solitary person (as Islam and Judaism hold) or one God in three persons (as Christianity confesses)? Did Jesus die on a cross (Christianity) or not (Islam)? Is the ultimate reality personal (the God of the Bible) or impersonal (much of Eastern thought)? These cannot all be true at once any more than a coin can be heads and tails on the same flip. To say "they're all the same" is not respect; it is quietly telling every devout believer that what they actually confess does not matter. The loving and honest path is to compare the claims openly and ask which is *true* — which is what this whole book has tried to do.

## **"If God is good, why is there so much evil and suffering?"**

This is the deepest objection of the human heart, and it deserves more than a slogan. Three things can be said honestly. First, the Bible never minimizes suffering or tells us to pretend it away; a third of the Psalms are laments, and God Himself, in Christ, wept at a grave. Second, much evil flows from the misuse of the freedom God gave creatures to love — a freedom that, to be real, had to be able to be abused. Third, and most importantly, the Christian answer to suffering is not finally a theory but a Person: a God who did not stay safely above the pain but entered it, was betrayed, tortured, and killed, and in that very suffering was working the world's rescue. The cross does not explain every "why," but it forever silences the charge that God is distant from our pain. He has a scar where the worst of it landed. Whatever else is unclear, this is sure: He is not indifferent.

## **"Hasn't science made God unnecessary?"**

Only if you confuse two different kinds of questions. Science is magnificent at describing *how* the universe works — the mechanisms, the laws, the processes. But "how" is not "why," and a mechanism is not a maker. To explain how an engine runs is not to explain why there is an engine, or a road, or anywhere to go. The deepest questions — why there is something rather than nothing, why the universe is ordered and intelligible, why there is consciousness, beauty, or a moral law written on the heart — are not the kind of questions a test tube can answer. Far from making God unnecessary, the existence of a rational, law-governed, comprehensible universe is exactly what you would expect if a rational Mind stood behind it. Many of the founders of modern science thought so, studying nature precisely because they expected the works of a faithful Creator to be orderly. Science describes the song; it cannot tell you whether there is a composer.

## **"How can a loving God send anyone to hell?"**

The question assumes God is eager to condemn — but the Bible's picture is of a God who "doesn't wish that any should perish, but that all should come to repentance" (2 Peter 3:9), who pleads, "Turn... for why will you die?" (Ezekiel 33:11). Judgment is real, because a God who shrugged at evil would not be good. But hell is not God dragging the unwilling to a place they did not choose; it is, at its root, God finally honoring a lifelong "no" — the tragic granting of a creature's settled refusal to have Him. The door of mercy stands open as wide as "all the ends of the earth" (Isaiah 45:22), and no one who comes is ever turned away. The wonder is not that some are lost; it is that, at infinite cost to Himself, *any* are saved. The same God who warns of judgment is the God who hung on a cross to spare us from it.

## **"Isn't the God of the Old Testament harsh — and different from the God of Jesus?"**

This is an ancient error (the early church named it after a teacher, Marcion, who tried to sever the two and was rejected as a heretic), and it dissolves on a closer reading. The same Old Testament that records God's judgments is the one that gives us "Yahweh, a merciful and gracious God, slow to anger, and abundant in loving kindness" (Exodus 34:6) — the most-quoted self-description of God in the whole Bible, and it comes from *Exodus*. And the same Jesus who shows us the Father's tenderness also speaks of judgment more vividly than anyone else in Scripture. The truth is that *both* Testaments hold severity and kindness together, because it is one God with one character throughout. Jesus did not come to rescue us *from* the Old Testament God; He came *as* that God in the flesh, to do what that God had promised all along. Read the whole story and you find not two Gods but one — holy and merciful from Genesis to Revelation.

## **"Can I really trust a God I can't see or prove like a science experiment?"**

We trust many real things we cannot put in a test tube — love, justice, our own minds, the reliability of reason itself. None of these are provable the way a chemical reaction is, yet life is unlivable without them. God is not less than these but more: the personal reality behind them. And the Bible's claim is not "leap blindly," but that God has given *evidence* suited to a personal Being — the witness of a created order that points beyond itself, the moral law written on every conscience, the historical person of Jesus and His resurrection, and the inward testimony of His Spirit to those who seek Him. Faith in the biblical sense is not believing without reasons; it is *trusting* a God who has given good reasons, the way you trust a person you have come to know. And the way to test it is the way you test any relationship — not from a safe distance, but by drawing near. "Taste and see that Yahweh is good" (Psalm

34:8). The invitation is experimental after all: come, and find out.

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## Appendix — Key Texts on the One God

A reference table for the doctrine of God traced in this book.

| Truth                   | Key text (WEB)                                                                                                       |
|-------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| God is one              | "Hear, Israel: Yahweh is our God. Yahweh is one."<br>(Deuteronomy 6:4)                                               |
| God's name is "I AM"    | "I AM WHO I AM... I AM has sent me to you."<br>(Exodus 3:14)                                                         |
| God is not a creature   | "God is not a man, that he should lie." (Numbers<br>23:19)                                                           |
| Plurality on page one   | "Let us make man in our image." (Genesis 1:26)                                                                       |
| The Spirit at creation  | "The Spirit of God was hovering over the surface of<br>the waters." (Genesis 1:2)                                    |
| Two figures, one throne | "One like a son of man came... to the Ancient of<br>Days." (Daniel 7:13-14)                                          |
| The Word was God        | "The Word was with God, and the Word was God."<br>(John 1:1)                                                         |
| The threefold name      | "baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the<br>Son and of the Holy Spirit." (Matthew 28:19)                 |
| The triune blessing     | "The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ, God's love, and<br>the fellowship of the Holy Spirit." (2 Corinthians<br>13:14) |
| The only Savior         | "I, even I, am Yahweh; and besides me there is no<br>savior." (Isaiah 43:11)                                         |
| One God for all nations | "Look to me, and be saved, all the ends of the earth."<br>(Isaiah 45:22)                                             |
| Knowing God is life     | "This is eternal life, that they should know you, the<br>only true God." (John 17:3)                                 |

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## Conclusion — Hear, and Live

The most important sentence in the world is still true: *Yahweh is our God. Yahweh is one.* This book has not undermined that confession; it has tried to open it — to show that the oneness of God is not a lonely, flat oneness but a fullness of life and love, eternally Father, Son, and Holy

Spirit; that this one God has a name, "I AM," and a face, Jesus Christ; that He alone saves, and He is near.

Trace the whole arc one last time. We began with a command — *Hear* — and discovered a God who speaks first, who introduces Himself rather than waiting to be found. We learned His name at a burning bush: "I AM," the self-existent One who needs nothing and gives everything, whose name overflows not with cold abstraction but with mercy, grace, and faithfulness. We watched Him refuse both errors about God — too holy to be controlled, too loving to stay away — drawing near behind a veil, in glimpses, in the strange figure of the Angel who is Yahweh, always teaching His people that His nearness has a face. We saw the fullness hidden inside the One: the Word, the Wisdom, the Breath, the "let us" of the garden, the two thrones of Daniel — until the New Testament unveiled what was always there, the one God eternally Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, a family of self-giving love older than the world. We heard His jealous, saving exclusivity — "besides me there is no savior" — and found it was not a tyrant's boast but a lover's vow, one door flung wide to all the earth. And we ended where all true theology ends: not in a lecture hall but on our knees, taught by the Spirit to call the unapproachable "I AM" by the name *Abba*, Father.

That is who God is. Not a force, not a projection, not a generic "higher power" we invent to suit ourselves — but the living God who has a name, a character, a face, and an open hand. To know this God is what you were made for, and you were made to love Him with all your heart, soul, and might, because nothing smaller will ever fill the place He alone was meant to hold. Every lesser god you might serve — money, success, romance, religion, the self — will in the end fail you and shape you into its own empty image. He will not fail you. He cannot, for He is "I AM."

So the Shema's first word is also its last word to you: *Hear*. Hear that God is one. Hear that He is near. Hear that the door is open and the price is paid and the Father is waiting. Hear — and do not merely add a fact to your mind, but turn, and trust, and come home. Hear, O Israel; hear, all the ends of the earth — and live.

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## About this book

*Hear, O Israel* is published freely by **Hope of Glory Ministry**, that the earth may be filled with the knowledge of the glory of the Lord. It may be read, shared, and given away without charge. All Scripture is from the World English Bible (public domain). We hold the historic Nicene faith and the plain reading of Scripture; we compare beliefs and never demean persons.

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*"For the earth will be filled with the knowledge of the glory of Yahweh, as the waters cover the sea." — Habakkuk 2:14 (WEB)*